

The Deficiencies of Dispensationalism

Both “classical” (Scofieldian/Chaferian) and “ultra” (hyper) dispensationalist theological traditions assert the following premises (among others):

- The work of the Holy Ghost pre-Acts was external, temporary, and selective.
 - The Spirit came “upon” specific individuals for specific tasks but did not permanently indwell or regenerate believers nor did He baptize anyone into a spiritual body.
- Pentecost (classical) or Acts 9/13/28 (hyper) marked the beginning of a brand new work of the Holy Ghost of permanent indwelling, spiritual regeneration, and the baptism of believers into the body of Christ.

Verses used to support the dispensationalist traditions:

- Exodus 31:3, Numbers 11:25
- Judges 6:34, 14:6, 15:14
- 1Samuel 16:14, Psalm 51:11, Nehemiah 9:30
- Luke 24:49
- John 7:37-39, 14:16-17, 16:7, 20:22
- Romans 8:9, 1Corinthians 12:13, Colossians 1:26, Titus 3:5
- Ephesians 1:13-14, 3:3-6, 4:30
- Classical
 - Acts 1:4-5, 2:1-4, 2:38, 8:15-17, 11:15, 19:2
- Hyper
 - Acts 9:17, 13:2,4, 28:25-28, Romans 16:25-26

Historicity of dispensational pneumatology

Dispensationalism was codified in the 19th and 20th centuries by theologians such as John Nelson Darby, C. I. Scofield (author of the Scofield Reference Bible), and Lewis Sperry Chafer (founder of Dallas Theological Seminary and author of *Systematic Theology*).

Dispensationalism divides Biblical history into distinct divine administrations or “dispensations” (eg. the Dispensation of Law in the Old Testament versus the Dispensation of Grace or Church Age in the New Testament).

Old Testament Period: The Holy Ghost’s work is viewed as external, temporary, and selective. Dispensationalists teach that the Spirit came “upon” specific individuals (such as kings, prophets, or judges) for specific tasks, but did not permanently indwell or regenerate believers as a standard rule, nor did He baptize anyone into a spiritual body.

New Testament Period (Pentecost Onward): Pentecost in Acts 2 is viewed as the absolute starting line for the Holy Ghost being “given.” In this view, Pentecost established a brand-new work of permanent indwelling, spiritual regeneration, and the baptism of believers into the body of Christ.

Rather than analyze all of the verses that dispensationalism uses to support their interpretation, instead we’re going to look at passages that present serious challenges to dispensationalism thereby disqualifying it as sound doctrine.

The universal “Law of being Reborn”

John 3:1-10

- ¹ There was a man of the Pharisees, named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews:
- ² The same came to Jesus by night, and said unto him, Rabbi, we know that thou art a teacher come from God: for no man can do these miracles that thou doest, except God be with him.
- ³ Jesus answered and said unto him, **Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.**
- ⁴ Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born?
- ⁵ Jesus answered, **Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.**
- ⁶ **That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.**
- ⁷ **Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again.**
- ⁸ **The wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.**
- ⁹ Nicodemus answered and said unto him, How can these things be?
- ¹⁰ Jesus answered and said unto him, **Art thou a master of Israel, and knowest not these things?**

Without even getting into the grammatical technicalities, Jesus' discourse with Nicodemus about *all* men needing a spiritual rebirth as a requirement to enter into the kingdom of God is **universally applicable**. That last part is a major problem for dispensationalism because it has no **Biblical** explanation for how people in the “old testament era” were reborn differently than how people are reborn in the “new testament era”. They do have an *explanation* for it – but that explanation lacks clear, Biblical proof (**1Thess 5:21**).

Think about Jesus' question to Nicodemus in verse 10 very carefully. Jesus **expected** Nicodemus to understand the concept of spiritual rebirth – and yet the new testament wasn't even written yet. That concept of being reborn that Jesus spoke of to Nicodemus was **nothing new**. It was something Nicodemus should have been well familiar with from studying the **old testament** Scriptures, not as some future event – but as something both he and the other Pharisees/Jews personally needed.

Note that in the clause “**Ye must be born again**” v7 – the pronoun “Ye” here **is not universal** – it resolves back to either “Jews” or “Pharisees” (pronouns and antecedents must agree in both gender and number).

Here is one example of where Nicodemus could have learned about the need for spiritual rebirth:

Genesis 2:16-17

- ¹⁶ And the LORD God commanded the man, saying, **Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat:**
- ¹⁷ **But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.**

God said “*in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.*” Did Adam and Eve physically die the day that they disobeyed God? They did not. But God said that that very same day they disobeyed they would die – so what exactly died that day out of the three options available (flesh, spirit, and soul)? If we connect what Jesus said back to Adam and Eve we can rightly come to the conclusion that they *died spiritually*.

One Spirit, One Work

In the new testament we see the phrases “Spirit of God”, “Spirit of Christ”, “Holy Ghost”, and “(H/h)oly Spirit” being used interchangeably because they are all different names for the same Spirit.

Luke 11:13

If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children: how much more shall your heavenly Father give **the Holy Spirit** to them that ask him?

Romans 8:9

But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the **Spirit of God** dwell in you. Now if **any man** have not the **Spirit of Christ**, he is none of his.

1 Corinthians 12:3

Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the **Spirit of God** calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by **the Holy Ghost**.

Ephesians 1:13

In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that **holy Spirit** of promise,

Ephesians 4:30

And grieve not the **holy Spirit of God**, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.

1 Thessalonians 4:8

He therefore that despiseth, despiseth not man, but God, who hath also given unto us **his holy Spirit**.

So then, what about the following passages:

1 Peter 1:9-12

⁹ Receiving the end of your faith, even the salvation of your souls.

¹⁰ Of which salvation **the prophets** have enquired and searched diligently, who prophesied of the grace that should come unto you:

¹¹ Searching what, or what manner of time the **Spirit of Christ** which was **in them** did signify, when it testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow.

¹² Unto whom it was revealed, that not unto themselves, but unto us they did minister the things, which are now reported unto you by them that have preached the gospel unto you with the Holy Ghost sent down from heaven; which things the angels desire to look into.

2 Peter 1:21

For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but **holy men of God** spake as they were moved by **the Holy Ghost**.

Notice that the Spirit of Christ was not upon them, it was **in them**. This directly contradicts the dispensationalist doctrine of “the Spirit was present with believers externally, but in believers internally only from Pentecost onward”. Despite that, dispensationalists use these verses to support their doctrine by **adding** a temporal (time) constraint where the word of God does not (**Deu 4:2**).

Dispensationalists also must ignore the clear differences between the Spirit coming upon a person, the Spirit filling a person, and Spiritual rebirth. They silently equate at least two of them to force the Scriptures into a rigid framework.

Adding, Assuming, and Ignoring

Many problems arise when we take the assertions of dispensationalism and then apply it to other passages. Here are just three examples of the common types of errors that arise from doing so.

Luke 1:15 (John the Baptist)

For he shall be great in the sight of the Lord, and shall drink neither wine nor strong drink; and **he shall be filled with the Holy Ghost, even from his mother's womb.**

- This is not a temporary event because the word of God provides no end to the temporal framework given.
- The temporal framework (timeline) we're given starts at "*from his mother's womb*" and we **are not given any end**.
- Therefore, adding an end to that temporal framework (by calling it temporary) when it does not exist constitutes **adding** to the word of God.

Luke 1:41

And it came to pass, that, when Elisabeth heard the salutation of Mary, the babe leaped in her womb; and **Elisabeth was filled with the Holy Ghost:**

Luke 1:67

And his father Zacharias was **filled with the Holy Ghost**, and prophesied, saying,

Luke 2:25

And, behold, there was a man in Jerusalem, whose name was Simeon; and the same man was just and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel: and **the Holy Ghost was upon him.**

- These *could be* temporary and extraordinary **and** they could not. Since the word of God does not contain an explicit timeline we can't prove either assertion with passages like these.

John 20:22

And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, **Receive ye the Holy Ghost:**

It's very easy to prove that this passage happened before Pentecost and there is no way around it without **ignoring the context**. Dispensationalism tries to explain this passage away by pulling it out of its context and changing when it happened. The simple grammar does not support doing so.

The Church began well before the New Testament

Acts 7:38

This is he, that was in **the church in the wilderness** with the angel which spake to him in the mount Sina, and with our fathers: who received the lively oracles to give unto us:

Ephesians 4:4

There is **one body**, and **one Spirit**, even as ye are called in **one hope** of your calling;

The body of Christ is also known as “the church”. Here we see “the church” explicitly referenced in the old testament. **Ephesians** makes it abundantly clear why we see the body of Christ in the old testament. This directly contradicts the dispensationalist doctrine of “the Church did not exist in the Old Testament”.

1 Corinthians 10:1-4

¹ Moreover, brethren, I would not that ye should be ignorant, how that all our fathers were under the cloud, and all passed through the sea;

² And were all baptized unto Moses in the cloud and in the sea;

³ And did all eat **the same** spiritual meat;

⁴ And did all drink **the same** spiritual drink: for they drank of that spiritual Rock that followed them: and that Rock was Christ.

This passage couldn't be any more clear that men, woman, and children in the old testament ate and drank from **the same** source as we do: the Spirit of Christ. Where does **the Bible** explain how they did that without being Spiritually reborn? Because for dispensationalism to be true, that Scriptural proof is required.

John 6:53-56

⁵⁶ **He that eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, dwelleth in me, and I in him.**

If we apply dispensationalism to these passages – no one before Pentecost hath eternal life. Because of that glaring problem, they made up something to explain how people in the old testament got saved.

Saved without the remission of sins

Hebrews 10:4

For **it is not possible** that the blood of bulls and of goats should take away sins.

Dispensationalists assert that

Old testament believers were saved under the economy of the law **through animal sacrifices** and temporary Spirit empowerments, whereas new testament believers are saved under grace through the permanent indwelling Spirit.

So along with **Heb 10:4** that means that old testament believers were saved but still retained their sins. Does that agree with the rest of the Bible?

In case you missed it

Romans 8:9

But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. **Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.**

The grammar of the last clause of **Rom 8:9** couldn't be any more simple: "*any man*" is **universally applicable**. It is not bound by any temporal framework. It applies just as much to old testament men and woman as it does to new testament men and women – which perfectly agrees with what Jesus said in **John 3**. The same cannot be truthfully said for dispensationalism.

The Conflation Dilemma

If we put the dispensationalist assertions together we arrive at a dilemma that I have called “the conflation dilemma” because it arises from equating two or more of the following three distinct types of events in the Bible:

1. the Spirit coming upon a person
2. the Spirit filling a person
3. Spiritual rebirth

Because dispensationalists deny that old testament saints were indwelt by the Holy Ghost, they are forced into one of two unsustainable positions regarding OT saints:

1. **Position A** (explicit conflation): They claim OT saints were saved *without* being reborn/indwelt by the Holy Ghost.
 - This directly contradicts [John 3:5](#) and [Romans 8:9](#).
2. **Position B** (inventing an unscriptural distinction)
 - Scholars like Lewis Sperry Chafer assert that OT saints were “regenerated” by the Spirit, but *not* “indwelt” or “sealed” by the Spirit. Where **exactly** does the Bible say that ([1Thess 5:21](#))?

The first two can easily be distinguished as distinct events by using the same verses we already looked at.

[John 20:22](#)

And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, **Receive ye the Holy Ghost:**

[Acts 2:4](#)

And they were all **filled with the Holy Ghost**, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.

- The disciples *received* the Holy Ghost well before Pentecost and later instead of *receiving* it again, we see that they were *filled* with the Holy Ghost. In every explicit example in the Bible that includes both the receiving and the subsequent filling of the Holy Spirit, the *filling of the Spirit* occurs **after receiving the Holy Spirit**.

The in-dwelling Spirit before Pentecost

Daniel 3:25

He answered and said, Lo, I see four men loose, walking in the midst of the fire, and they have no hurt; and the form of the fourth is like **the Son of God**.

Matthew 16:15-16

¹⁵ He saith unto them, **But whom say ye that I am?**

¹⁶ And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, **the Son of the living God**.

John 11:27

She saith unto him, Yea, Lord: I believe that thou art the Christ, **the Son of God**, which should come into the world.

1 John 4:15

Whosoever shall confess^{G3670} that Jesus is the Son of God, **God dwelleth in him**, and he in God.

- “Whosoever” is universally applicable.
- “confess” is an action done with the mouth (*homologeō* = *homou* + *logos*).
- The Holy Spirit dwelled **in** Nebuchadnezzar, Peter, and Martha **long** before the book of **Acts**.

1 Corinthians 12:3

Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that **no man can say that Jesus is the Lord**^{G2962}, **but by the Holy Ghost**.

Calling Jesus God or LORD fits under this clause. So what about all the following passages where someone does exactly that well before Pentecost? Under the assertions of dispensationalism every single one of these was a temporary, extraordinary act of the Holy Spirit because they all happened before Pentecost. I've highlighted the most interesting references in red.

- **Matthew 3:3**, **Mark 1:3**, **Luke 3:4**, **John 1:23** (John the Baptist; Isaiah the prophet **Isa 40:3**; Malachi the prophet **Mal 3:1**)
- **Matthew 8:2** (a leper)
- **Matthew 8:6,8** (a centurion)
- **Matthew 8:21** (another of His disciples)
- **Matthew 8:25** (His disciples)
- **Matthew 9:28** (two blind men)
- **Matthew 14:28,30**, **16:22**, **17:4**, **18:21**, **Luke 5:8**, **12:41**, **22:33**, **John 6:68**, **13:6,9**, **13:36,37**, **21:15,16,17,20,21**, **Acts 1:21** (Peter; Simon Peter)
- **Matthew 15:22,25,27**, **Mark 7:28** (a women of Canaan; a Greek; a Syrophenician)
- **Matthew 17:15** (a certain man)
- **Matthew 20:30,31,33** (two blind men)
- **Matthew 26:22** (the disciples)
- **Matthew 27:10** (Jeremiah the prophet)
- **Matthew 28:6** (the angel of the Lord)
- **Mark 9:24** (one of the multitude; the father of the child)
- **Mark 16:19,20** (John Mark; Marcus; Mark)
- **Luke 1:76** (Zacharias; cf. **1:67**)
- **Luke 2:11** (the angel of the Lord)
- **Luke 5:12** (a man full of leprosy)
- **Luke 6:5**, **John 13:13** (Jesus; well after His baptism)
- **Luke 7:6** (the centurion)

- Luke 9:54 (James and John)
- Luke 9:57,59 (a certain man; another man)
- Luke 10:17 (the seventy)
- Luke 10:40, John 11:21,27, 11:39 (Martha)
- Luke 11:1 (one of His disciples)
- Luke 13:23 (one)
- Luke 17:5 (the apostles)
- Luke 17:6, 18:6, 24:3 (Luke; Lucas; the beloved physician)
- Luke 18:41 (a certain blind man)
- Luke 19:8 (Zacchaeus)
- Luke 19:34 (they that were sent)
- Luke 22:38 (they; certain apostles)
- Luke 22:49 (they which were about Him)
- Luke 23:42 (one of the thieves on the cross next to Jesus)
- Luke 24:34 (two disciples headed to Emmaus)
- John 6:23, 11:2, 13:25, 20:20, 21:7,12 (John)
- John 6:34 (the people)
- John 8:11 (the woman taken in adultery)
- John 9:36,38 (a man which was blind from his birth)
- John 11:3 (Lazarus's sisters)
- John 11:12 (His disciples)
- John 11:32 (Mary; Martha's sister)
- John 11:34 (Mary and the Jews with her)
- John 14:5, 20:28 (Thomas)
- John 14:8 (Philip)
- John 14:22 (Judas, not Iscariot)
- John 20:2,13,18 (Mary Magdalene)
- John 20:25 (the other disciples)
- Acts 1:24 (the disciples)

The elephant in the room

John 7:37-39

³⁷ In the last day, that great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried, saying, **If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink.**

³⁸ **He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.**

³⁹ (But this spake he of the Spirit, which they that believe on him should receive: for the Holy Ghost was not yet given; because that Jesus was not yet glorified.)

Through the lens of dispensationalism or through any other false doctrine that takes advantage of your lack of knowledge of the English language, it's impossible to properly interpret this passage.

As we have seen several times already (Joh 3:1-10, Rom 8:9, Luk 1:15,41,67, 2:25, 1Co 10:1-4, 1Pe 1:11, et. al.), and can observe in other passages, God's Spirit was clearly given well before Jesus was glorified. Here are a few more examples that clearly contradict the dispensationalist interpretation:

Numbers 11:25 (cf. Rom 12:6, 1Co 12:10)

And the LORD came down in a cloud, and spake unto him, and **took of the spirit that was upon him, and gave it unto the seventy elders**: and it came to pass, that, when the spirit rested upon them, **they prophesied, and did not cease.**

Isaiah 63:11

Then he remembered the days of old, **Moses**, and his people, saying, Where is he that brought them up out of the sea with **the shepherd of his flock**? where is he that **put his holy Spirit within** him?

Nehemiah 9:20

Thou gavest also thy good spirit to instruct them, and withheldest not thy manna from their mouth, and gavest them water for their thirst.

Nehemiah 9:30

Yet many years didst thou forbear them, and testifiedst against them by **thy spirit in thy prophets**: yet would they not give ear: therefore gavest thou them into the hand of the people of the lands.

Those examples alone make it **impossible** for John 7:37-39 to mean "the Holy Ghost was not given to anyone before Jesus was glorified". When we use proper English grammar, one word (sort of) changes everything:

John 7:37-39

³⁷ In the last day, that great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried, saying, **If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink.**

³⁸ **He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.**

³⁹ (But **this** spake he of the Spirit, which they that believe on him should receive: for the Holy Ghost was not yet given; because that Jesus was not yet glorified.)

The demonstrative pronoun "*this*" points **strictly** to "*out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water*". In other words, the grammar **does not** permit universal application (eg. "*for the Holy Ghost was not yet given* [for **this** purpose]"). In its context, this passage has **nothing** to do with being reborn and deals specifically, and only, with the fulfillment of the prophecy from Joel 2:28-32 which Peter confirms:

Acts 2:33

Therefore being by the right hand of God exalted, and having received of the Father the promise of the Holy Ghost, **he hath shed forth this**, which ye now see and hear.

The keys to the kingdom

It's pretty amazing what we can learn when we use proper English grammar and we let Scripture interpret itself. Here is one of many such examples.

Genesis 15:6

And he believed **in** the LORD; and he counted it to him for righteousness.

1 Peter 1:17-21

¹⁷ And if **ye** call on the Father, who without respect of persons judgeth according to every man's work, pass the time of **your** sojourning here in fear:

¹⁸ Forasmuch as **ye** know that **ye** were not redeemed with corruptible things, as silver and gold, from **your** vain conversation received by tradition from **your** fathers;

¹⁹ But with the precious blood of **Christ**, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot:

²⁰ **Who** verily was foreordained before the foundation of the world, but was manifest in these last times for **you**,

²¹ **Who** by **him** do believe **in** God, that raised **him** up from the dead, and gave **him** glory; that **your** faith and hope might be in God.

John 8:56

Your father **Abraham** rejoiced to see **my day: and he saw it**, and was glad.

Galatians 3:8

And the scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the heathen through faith, **preached before the gospel unto Abraham**, saying, In thee shall all nations be blessed.

Normally, when we read **Genesis 15:6** we might gloss over it and read it as “Abram believed what the LORD said” but that is not actually what it says! Again, one word changes everything.

It says “*And [Abram] believed **IN** the LORD*”. For it to mean “Abram believed what the LORD promised” the “*in*” would have to be removed (eg. “And he believed the LORD”).

Now, if we read **1 Peter 1:17-21** very carefully it tells us “*Who by [Christ] do believe **IN** God...*”. When we put the two passages together we get:

Abram believed in the LORD by Christ

And by extension, because **1 Peter 1:17-21** applies to any believer we learn that it is only through the Spirit of Christ that **anyone** can believe that God exists and is real.

Dispensationalists attempt to explain away **1 Peter 1:17-21** by arbitrarily forcing the temporal clause in verse 20 (“was manifest in these **last times** for you”) onto the universal truth in verse 21 (“Who by him do believe in God”), which necessitates ignoring English grammar rules.